



WHY THE THINGS YOU BUY ARE EXPENSIVE, BADLY DESIGNED, UNSAFE, & USUALLY DON'T WORK!

DESIGN FOR THE REAL WORLD

a literature review zine based on the work of:
Victor Papanek - Design For The Real
World: Human Ecology and Social Change

THE DESIGNER'S CRIME

"There are professions more harmful than industrial design, but only a very few of them."

INDUSTRIAL SINS

- Advertising design, focused on persuading people to buy things they don't need..
- Industrial design runs a close second, concocting "tawdry idiocies".
- Industrial design, operating on a mass production basis, has "put murder on a mass production basis," with unsafe automobiles killing or maiming nearly one million people worldwide each year.
- Designers pollute the environment and create permanent garbage that clutters the landscape.

THE REAL JOB: Industrial design is only associated with production and manufacturing facilities, suggesting a focus on profit rather than human needs. If design is a problem-solving activity, the designer abdicates responsibility by acting as a "pimp for the sales department".

OUR KLEENEX CULTURE

"You have to make up your mind either to make sense or to make money, if you want to be a designer." — R. Buckminster Fuller

We live in a "Kleenex Culture" where everything, from automobiles to consumer goods, is considered a "throw-away item". People are persuaded into throwing away their cars every three years and their clothes twice yearly.

Three Types of Obsolescence:

1. **TECHNOLOGICAL:** A better or more elegant way of doing things is discovered.
2. **MATERIAL:** The product wears out.
3. **ARTIFICIAL:** The materials are substandard or components are not replaceable/repairable, wearing out in a predictable time frame.

Since World War II, our major commitment has been to stylistic and artificial obsolescence (the death-rating of a product).



This zine is part of a collection of literature reviews for my graduate thesis that reimagine academic research through visual design.

learn and find more @
zahrabaxi.com/theiliteratureproject



or scan me :)

zine #3
designed, illustrated, & printed by zahra baxi
© 2025

CALL TO ACTION

"As socially and morally involved designers, we must address ourselves to the needs of a world with its back to the wall while the hands on the clock point perpetually to one minute before twelve."

THE CHOICE IS NOT... between corporate gray vs "reek-out, high on LSD".

THE THIRD WAY: A new crusade is needed for design that exists all over the world, addressing vast areas of need. The designer must become a "community problem-solver".

A DESIGNERS WORK COULD INCLUDE...

- Medical diagnostic devices & hospital equipment.
- Teaching aids for specialized fields.
- Integrated design teams and cross-disciplinary understanding drawing on sociology, biology, anthropology, and psychology.

DESIGNING FOR THE PEOPLE NOT & FOR
CAPITALISM

BREAKING THE BLOCKS

Designers often lack ways of solving new problems because of perceptual, cultural, associational, and emotional blocks. We must learn to overcome these limitations.

Key Blocks to Overcome

- **PERCEPTUAL:** Physical or mental restrictions, like color-blindness or deafness, inhibiting the intake of sensory data. Might not be "change-able" but find work arounds, find the ability in a disability.
- **CULTURAL:** Taboos and norms imposed by the cultural surroundings, hindering independent thinking
- **ASSOCIATIONAL:** Relying on previous methods or established connections, which are preventing new insights.
- **EMOTIONAL:** Fear of making a mistake, desire for security, or lack of drive to pursue an idea for fear of failure.

The designer must strive to transcend the "Triad of Limitations" (fate, "god", destiny, or sheer accident). The goal is to realize the full potentiality of humanity's being.

DESIGN FOR GLOBAL NEEDS

Find bold, practical solutions to the problems of industrial design and solve the urgent problems threatening mankind. Design must be relevant to the needs of people in the world today

SOME CASE STUDIES

- **9¢ Radio Receiver:** Made of a used juice can, paraffin wax, and a wick as a power source; manufacturing costs of 9 cents. Fundamental communications device for non-literate / low income areas of the world.
- **Low-cost TV Set (Project UJAMAH):** Final concept can be made for considerably less than \$9. Used ABS Resin. Labor, manufacturing, and material cost the Japanese manufacturer less than \$18 for a similar market-competitive set. Educational television for Africa, devoted primarily to educational needs.
- **Canes for the Blind:** Hand-aligned fiber optics; glow in the dark; provide a more sensitive tactile feedback. Addressing needs of the disabled, & elderly who are often neglected by designers

